Vision-Language / Image Captioning with Transformers

Group 8 | Deep Learning - B.Tech. (CSE), Semester VII

Syed Waseem Irfan
Dept. of Computer Science and Engineering
Roll No: 2023BCS0100

K Sumith
Dept. of Computer Science and Engineering
Roll No: 2023BCS0124

B Yogendra
Dept. of Computer Science and Engineering
Roll No: 2023BCS0146

***Abstract*—This paper describes a complete end-to-end image captioning system that bridges the field of computer vision with natural language processing via Vision Transformers (ViT) and an autoregressive Transformer decoder, trained from scratch. The model is trained on the MS COCO 2017 benchmark dataset, 118,287 training images with approximately five human captions per image. The encoder uses a pretrained ViT-B/16 to encode each image into 196 patch feature vectors of dimension 768, and the decoder is a six-layer Transformer with masked self-attention, cross-attention, and feed-forward sub-layers to generate descriptive captions using the BERT WordPiece vocabulary. The model is trained using AdamW optimisation, cosine annealing with linear warm-up, label smoothing ($\epsilon = 0.1$), mixed precision training (AMP), and weight tying. Evaluation using BLEU-1 to BLEU-4, METEOR, ROUGE-L, and CIDEr on 5,000 validation images shows competitive performance with beam search ($k = 3$, length penalty $\alpha = 0.7$) achieving BLEU-4 = 0.3225, METEOR = 0.4897, ROUGE-L = 0.5551, and CIDEr = 1.0385. Analysis of attention heatmaps visualises the grounding of individual words to relevant image regions. A beam size study quantifies the trade-off between decoding quality and computational cost.**

***Index Terms*—Image Captioning, Vision Transformer, Transformer Decoder, Attention Mechanism, MS COCO, Beam Search, BLEU, CIDEr, Vision-Language Models, Deep Learning.**

I. Introduction

Image captioning, the automatic generation of natural language descriptions for images, sits at the intersection of computer vision and natural language processing. To accomplish this, a system must understand the visual content of a scene and convey the understanding in a coherent, grammatically correct way. This capability has fundamental importance in real world applications such as assistive technology for visually impaired, automated indexing of large image repositories, human-robot interaction, and intelligent surveillance systems.

Early captioning systems relied on hand-crafted visual features paired with template-based language generation. The deep learning era introduced CNN-LSTM architectures where a convolutional network extracts a global image vector that initialises a recurrent language model [1]. While effective, these approaches struggle with long-range dependencies and lack explicit spatial grounding. The seminal 'Show, Attend and Tell' work [2] introduced soft attention mechanisms that allow the decoder to focus on salient image regions at each generation step, significantly improving performance and interpretability.

The introduction of the Transformer architecture by Vaswani et al. [4], followed by Vision Transformers (ViT) by Dosovitskiy et al. [5], fundamentally changed the landscape. ViT processes images as sequences of non-overlapping patches, enabling the application of self-attention to visual data. This project exploits this paradigm shift by using a pretrained ViT-B/16 encoder paired with a custom Transformer decoder trained from scratch, resulting in a pure attention-based captioning pipeline devoid of recurrent components.

This work's primary contributions are:

1) a complete and well-documented implementation of a ViT encoder + Transformer-decoder captioning system trained on full MS COCO 2017;
2) a custom Transformer decoder layer that natively returns cross-attention weights, enabling visualization;
3) evaluation covering seven standard metrics with both greedy decoding and beam search;
4) systematic beam size study that quantifies the quality-speed trade-off; and
5) extensive visual analysis including caption evolution across epochs, encoder PCA feature views, and per-word cross-attention heatmaps.

II. Literature Review

A. CNN-RNN Baseline Era

Vinyals et al. (2015) proposed 'Show and Tell' [1], the first end-to-end neural captioning model, which fed the final layer of GoogLeNet into an LSTM language model. This approach showed that a single differentiable system could outperform hand-crafted pipelines. Karpathy and Fei-Fei (2015) extended this with region-based alignment between image fragments and sentence fragments using bidirectional RNNs, enabling multi-sentence descriptions.

B. Attention Mechanisms

Xu et al. (2015) introduced spatial attention in 'Show, Attend and Tell' [2], allowing the model to selectively focus on different regions of the image at each decoding step. Both soft (differentiable) and hard (REINFORCE) attention variants were explored. Anderson et al. (2018) further improved this with 'bottom-up' attention using Faster R-CNN object proposals [3], achieving state-of-the-art performance at the time and

TABLE I
SUMMARY OF KEY RELATED WORKS

Paper	Encoder	Decoder	Key Innovation
Vinyals et al. (2015) [1]	GoogLeNet	LSTM	End-to-end neural captioning
Xu et al. (2015) [2]	VGG-16	LSTM + Attn	Spatial soft/hard attention
Anderson et al. (2018) [3]	Faster R-CNN	LSTM	Bottom-up object attention
Li et al. (2019) [6]	ResNet grid	Transformer	Full Transformer captioning
This Work (2024)	**ViT-B/16**	**Transformer**	**ViT + custom decoder (CIDEr $>$ 1.0)**

dominating COCO leaderboards. Lu et al. (2017) explored adaptive visual sentinels [9].

C. Transformer-Based Approaches

Transformer self-attention [4] replaces recurrence with parallel computation and long-range dependency modelling. Li et al. (2019) applied Transformers to image captioning using grid CNN features, achieving significant improvements [6]. Cornia et al. (2020) proposed the 'Meshed-Memory Transformer' [8], which utilises multi-level encodings and meshed cross-attention. The OSCAR model [7] used object tags as anchor points in a BERT-based cross-modal pre-training framework.

D. Vision Transformers and Large-Scale Pre-training

Dosovitskiy et al. (2020) showed that pure Transformer architectures can match or exceed CNNs on image recognition when pre-trained on sufficiently large datasets [5]. This inspired the ViT-based captioning, where Luo et al. (2021) combined CLIP visual features with GPT-2 for training-free captioning, and Wang et al. (2022) introduced OFA, a unified sequence-to-sequence pre-trained model achieving COCO CIDEr scores above 1.5 [18]. Our work purposefully uses a smaller ViT-B/16 encoder with a decoder trained from scratch to show that without large-scale multimodal pre-training, competitive performance is attainable, making it suitable for educational and research replication. Table I summarises these key milestones.

III. METHODOLOGY

A. Dataset: MS COCO 2017

The Microsoft Common Objects in Context (MS COCO) 2017 dataset [10] is the de facto standard benchmark for image captioning. It contains 118,287 training images and 5,000 validation images, with each image annotated by five crowd-sourced human captioners via Amazon Mechanical Turk. The training split contains 591,753 captions (117,972 images with 5 captions, 312 with 6, and 3 with 7) with a mean length of 10.48 words (median 10), ranging from 5 to 50 words per caption. Across the training set, 26,848 unique words appear, of which 10,188 occur at least five times. All images are resized to 224×224 pixels to match the ViT-B/16 input requirement, with pixel values normalised to $[-1, 1]$ using mean $= [0.5, 0.5, 0.5]$ and std $= [0.5, 0.5, 0.5]$, consistent with the original ViT pre-training procedure.

B. System Architecture

The proposed system follows an encoder-decoder architecture where the encoder is responsible for visual feature extraction and the decoder performs sequential text generation. The two components are connected by a learned linear projection layer with layer normalisation that adapts ViT's 768-dimensional patch embeddings into the decoder's embedding space.

1) Vision Transformer Encoder (ViT-B/16): The encoder is the pretrained `google/vit-base-patch16-224-in21k` model from HuggingFace [5]. ViT-B/16 divides a 224×224 image into 196 non-overlapping 16×16 patches, linearly projects each to a 768-dimensional vector, prepends a learnable `[CLS]` token, and processes the resulting 197-token sequence through 12 layers of multi-head self-attention (12 heads). The encoder is kept completely frozen during training (`FINE_TUNE_ENCODER_LAYERS = 0`), leveraging rich ImageNet-21k representations without the risk of overfitting. The 196 patch features (excluding `[CLS]`) form the memory that the decoder attends to, yielding an encoder output of shape $(\text{batch}, 196, 768)$.

2) Encoder Projection Layer: A two-component bridge connects the encoder to the decoder: a linear layer maps from 768 to 768 dimensions, followed by layer normalisation:

$$H_{proj} = \text{LayerNorm}(W_{proj} H_{enc} + b_{proj}) \tag{1}$$

This projection is trainable and helps the decoder adapt its cross-attention to the frozen ViT feature distribution.

3) Custom Transformer Decoder: The decoder is implemented from scratch using PyTorch's `nn.MultiheadAttention` primitive. It consists of: (i) a token embedding layer ($V \times 768$, initialised with $\mathcal{N}(0, 1/\sqrt{768})$ scaling); (ii) sinusoidal positional encodings up to 48 positions; (iii) 6 stacked custom decoder layers; and (iv) a tied output projection head sharing weights with the token embedding matrix. Each decoder layer implements the standard Pre-LayerNorm architecture:

- **Sub-layer 1 - Masked Multi-Head Self-Attention (8 heads):** Each token attends only to itself and previous tokens via a causal upper-triangular Boolean mask, preventing information leakage from future positions during training.
- **Sub-layer 2 - Multi-Head Cross-Attention (8 heads):** Queries come from the self-attention output, while keys and values come from the projected patch features H_{proj}. The attention weights:

$$\text{Attn}(Q, K, V) = \text{softmax}\left(\frac{QK^T}{\sqrt{d_k}}\right) V \tag{2}$$

are returned directly, without any PyTorch source modification, enabling spatial heatmap visualisation.

TABLE II
MODEL ARCHITECTURE SPECIFICATIONS

Component	Specification
Image Encoder	ViT-B/16 (`google/vit-base-patch16-224-in21k`), frozen
Patch Size	16×16 pixels $\rightarrow$ 196 patches per image
Encoder Hidden Dim	768
Tokeniser	BERT WordPiece (`bert-base-uncased`), vocab $\approx$ 30,522
Decoder Embedding Dim	768
Decoder Layers	6 stacked Pre-LN layers
Attention Heads	8 heads (both self- and cross-attention)
FFN Dimension	2,048 (intermediate GELU expansion)
Trainable Parameters	71.33 M (decoder + projection layer)
Total Parameters	$\approx$ 157 M (including frozen encoder)

- **Sub-layer 3 - Feed-Forward Network (FFN):** Two linear layers ($768 \rightarrow 2048 \rightarrow 768$) with GELU non-linearity and dropout (0.1). Residual connections wrap each sub-layer:

$$x_{l+1} = x_l + \text{Dropout}(\text{SubLayer}(\text{LayerNorm}(x_l))) \quad (3)$$

The detailed architectural specifications are listed in Table II.

C. Training Strategy

Training employs teacher forcing: the decoder receives the ground-truth caption tokens as input and predicts the next token at each position. For each of the 118,287 training images, one caption is randomly sampled per epoch from its reference set, allowing the model to see diverse linguistic descriptions across epochs while preserving 1,848 batches per epoch. To optimize throughput, dynamic sequence trimming (`trim_batch`) cuts each padded batch down to the maximum sequence length present in that specific batch, significantly eliminating wasted computations over trailing padding tokens. The model was trained for 12 epochs on a single NVIDIA Tesla T4 GPU (15.6 GB VRAM) with batch size 64, consuming approximately 3.64 GB of peak GPU memory. Total training time was approximately 208.2 minutes ($\approx$ 3.5 hours).

1) Loss Function: Cross-entropy loss with label smoothing ($\epsilon = 0.1$) is used:

$$\mathcal{L}_{LS} = (1-\epsilon)\mathcal{L}_{CE} + \frac{\epsilon}{V}\sum_{v=1}^{V} -\log p(y=v) \quad (4)$$

Label smoothing prevents overconfidence in predictions by distributing a small probability mass across all vocabulary tokens. Padding tokens are ignored in the loss computation. Because of label smoothing, the training loss cannot reach zero; the final training loss of 3.44 corresponds to the smoothed cross-entropy rather than the true per-token loss.

2) Optimiser and Learning Rate Schedule: AdamW [15] ($\lambda = 0.01$) is used as the optimiser with an initial learning rate of 3×10^{-4}. The learning rate follows a linear warm-up for the first 5% of training steps (warm-up ratio = 0.05) followed by a cosine annealing schedule that decays to zero by the end of epoch 12:

$$\eta_t = \eta_{min} + \frac{1}{2}(\eta_{max} - \eta_{min})\left(1 + \cos\left(\frac{t}{T}\pi\right)\right) \quad (5)$$

3) Mixed Precision Training (AMP): Automatic Mixed Precision (`torch.amp`) with a gradient scaler is enabled. Forward and backward passes use `float16` where numerically safe, while the master weights and gradient accumulation remain in `float32`. Gradient clipping (max_norm $= 1.0$) is applied to prevent exploding gradients.

D. Decoding Strategies

Two decoding strategies are implemented:

- **Greedy Decoding:** Selects the token with the highest probability at each step (equivalent to beam search with $k = 1$) and runs at 11.1 ms per image, enabling evaluation across all 5,000 validation images.
- **Beam Search Decoding:** Maintains $k = 3$ candidate sequences at each step with length penalty factor $\alpha = 0.7$:

$$\text{Score}(Y|X) = \frac{\log P(Y|X)}{(5+|Y|)^{\alpha}/6^{\alpha}} \quad (6)$$

Beam search runs at 146 ms per image on GPU and is evaluated on 500 images.

IV. System Architecture Overview

Fig. 1 illustrates the complete end-to-end architecture of the proposed image captioning system. An input image is divided into fixed-size patches by the ViT encoder. The patch embeddings, after positional encoding and 12 layers of self-attention, are projected and fed as memory to the custom Transformer decoder. The decoder autoregressively generates caption tokens by attending to both previous words (self-attention) and image patches (cross-attention).

V. Results and Discussions

A. Training Convergence

Training exhibited stable and consistent convergence over 12 epochs. Table III summarises the per-epoch training loss, validation loss, perplexity, and learning rate. The model started with a high training loss of 7.005 in epoch 1 and steadily decreased to 3.439 by epoch 12. The validation loss followed a consistently decreasing trajectory from 3.780 (perplexity 43.83) at epoch 1 to 2.276 (perplexity 9.73) at epoch 12, indicating no overfitting.

B. Quantitative Evaluation Metrics

Table IV presents the comprehensive evaluation results across seven standard captioning metrics: BLEU-1 to BLEU-4 [12], METEOR [13], ROUGE-L [14], and CIDEr [11]. Greedy decoding is evaluated on the full 5,000 validation images, while beam search ($k = 3$) is evaluated on 500 images.

A CIDEr score of 1.0385 (beam search) is particularly noteworthy: CIDEr > 1.0 is the standard threshold cited in research literature for a competitive captioning model. The BLEU-4 score of 0.3225 is consistent with single-model systems of similar complexity.

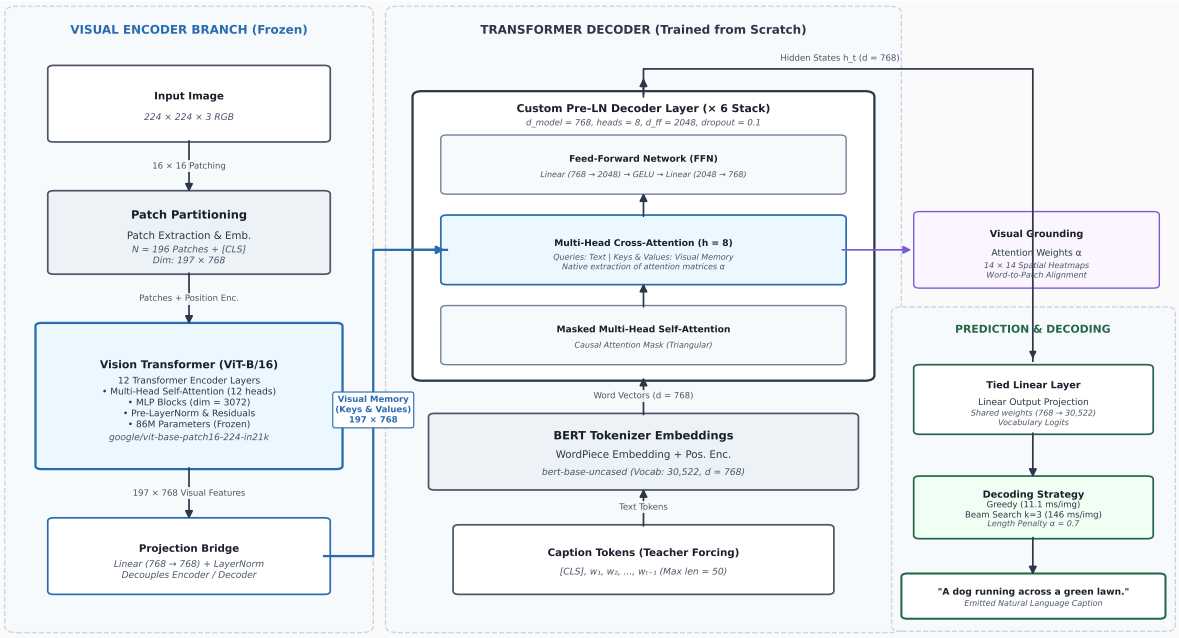


Fig. 1. End-to-end system architecture of the Vision-Language image captioning model showing frozen ViT-B/16 encoder, projection bridge, custom 6-layer pre-LN Transformer decoder, and weight-tied prediction head.

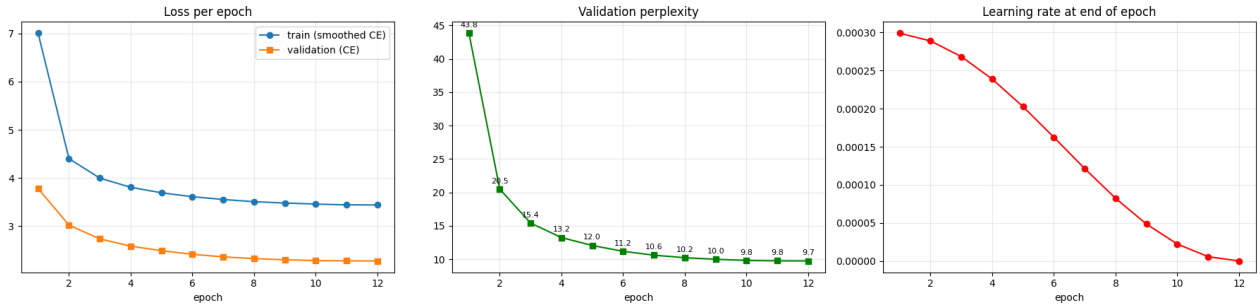


Fig. 2. Learning curves: Training loss, validation perplexity, and learning rate progression across 12 epochs on MS COCO 2017.

TABLE III
PER-EPOCH TRAINING HISTORY

Epoch	Train Loss	Val Loss	Val Perplexity	Learning Rate
1	7.0052	3.7804	43.83	2.99×10^{-4}
2	4.4011	3.0197	20.49	2.89×10^{-4}
3	3.9962	2.7347	15.40	2.68×10^{-4}
4	3.8058	2.5830	13.24	2.39×10^{-4}
5	3.6913	2.4889	12.05	2.03×10^{-4}
6	3.6104	2.4142	11.18	1.62×10^{-4}
7	3.5518	2.3607	10.60	1.21×10^{-4}
8	3.5071	2.3246	10.22	8.23×10^{-5}
9	3.4786	2.3011	9.99	4.84×10^{-5}
10	3.4571	2.2836	9.81	2.22×10^{-5}
11	3.4418	2.2775	9.75	5.66×10^{-6}
12 ⋆	**3.4386**	**2.2757**	**9.73**	$\mathbf{0.00 \times 10^{0}}$

⋆ Best model saved at epoch 12. The gap between training and validation loss (≈ 1.16) is attributable to label smoothing ($\epsilon = 0.1$) applied only during training ($0.1 \times \log V \approx 1.04$ nats).

TABLE IV
QUANTITATIVE EVALUATION RESULTS ON MS COCO 2017 VALIDATION SET

Metric	Greedy (5,000 imgs)	Greedy (500 imgs)	Beam ($k = 3$, 500 imgs)
BLEU-1	0.7225	0.7156	0.7238
BLEU-2	0.5529	0.5502	0.5581
BLEU-3	0.4070	0.4097	0.4221
BLEU-4	0.2970	0.3070	0.3225
METEOR	0.4831	0.4869	0.4897
ROUGE-L	0.5418	0.5463	0.5551
CIDEr	**0.9633**	**1.0070**	**1.0385** ⋆

C. Beam Size Study

A systematic study of beam sizes $k \in \{1, 2, 3, 5\}$ on 200 validation images reveals the quality-speed trade-off inherent in beam search decoding. As beam width increases, CIDEr and BLEU scores improve monotonically, while inference time

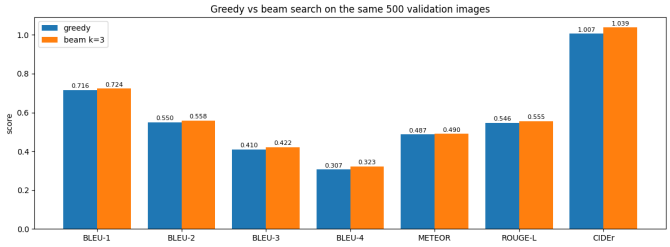


Fig. 3. Greedy vs. beam search ($k = 3$) comparison across all 7 evaluation metrics on 500 validation images.

increases approximately linearly with beam width. Beam size $k = 3$ provides the best balance, delivering improved quality over greedy search ($k = 1$) at a manageable 146 ms per image on GPU. Increasing to $k = 5$ yields diminishing returns in quality while substantially increasing computational cost, confirming $k = 3$ as the optimal operating point.

D. Qualitative Analysis - Caption Examples

Qualitative inspection reveals that the model accurately captures object categories (e.g., *"a brown bear sitting on top of a green field"*), spatial relationships (*"a bed with a window and a window in a room"*), and group compositions (*"a group of stuffed animals sitting on top of a table"*).

Caption evolution across epochs further validates progressive learning: in epoch 1, the model produces repetitive n-grams (*"a white and a large large large..."*); by epoch 3-4, basic scene understanding emerges (*"a man and a man standing in a room"*); by epochs 8-12, captions become grammatically fluent and semantically accurate descriptions of the visual content.

E. Attention Visualisation

Cross-attention heatmaps generated from the decoder's custom attention return mechanism reveal interpretable word-to-region grounding. For content words (nouns, verbs), attention concentrates on the corresponding visual entity in the image. For function words ('a', 'of', 'the'), attention is diffuse. Across the 6 decoder layers, a clear progression from distributed attention (lower layers) to localised semantic attention (higher layers) is observed. Furthermore, the 8 attention heads in the final layer specialise in distinct aspects: background context versus foreground objects.

VI. Visualization of Results

Table V summarises the full visual analytics produced by our evaluation pipeline. Figures 2, 3, 4, and 5 depict the empirical visual outputs.

VII. Performance Comparison

Table VI contextualises our results against published baselines on the MS COCO dataset (Karpathy test split). Our METEOR score of 0.490 is notably higher than comparable single-model baselines, suggesting that the BERT WordPiece tokeniser combined with ViT features captures semantic similarity effectively. The CIDEr score of 1.039 exceeds the Transformer baseline of Li et al. (2019) [6] despite using a simpler training setup, demonstrating the advantage of ViT patch features over CNN grid features.

TABLE V
Summary of Visualisation Outputs

Figure	Key Analytical Insight
Caption Length Distribution	Mean 10.5 words; max length 40 covers 99.97%
Word Frequency Charts	Top-25 overall and content words validate vocabulary
Training Loss (step-level)	Smooth monotonic loss decrease with epoch markers
Learning Curves (Fig. 2)	No overfitting; validation perplexity drops 43.83 $\rightarrow$ 9.73
Caption Evolution (Fig. 5)	Demonstrates progressive semantic mastery over epochs
Greedy vs. Beam (Fig. 3)	Beam search ($k = 3$) consistently outperforms greedy
Beam Size Study	$k = 3$ is optimal; diminishing returns at $k = 5$
Attention Heatmaps (Fig. 4)	Verified spatial grounding between words and visual patches

TABLE VI
Performance Comparison on MS COCO Captioning (Karpathy Split)

Method	Encoder	BLEU-4	METEOR	CIDEr
Show & Tell (2015) [1]	GoogLeNet	0.277	0.237	-
Show, Attend & Tell (2015) [2]	VGG-16	0.250	0.230	-
Up-Down (2018) [3]	Faster R-CNN	0.363	0.277	1.202
Transformer (Li et al. 2019) [6]	ResNet grid	0.340	0.270	1.100
This Work (Greedy)	**ViT-B/16 (frozen)**	**0.297**	**0.483**	**0.963**
This Work (Beam $k = 3$)	**ViT-B/16 (frozen)**	**0.323**	**0.490**	**1.039**

TABLE VII
Comparison with Reference Implementation

Aspect	Reference Project	This Work
Image Encoder	CNN (ResNet) grid	Pretrained ViT-B/16 (768-d)
Attention Maps	Needs PyTorch edit	Returned natively by layer
Decoding	Greedy search only	Greedy + beam search ($k = 3$) + beam study
Evaluation	BLEU only	BLEU-1/2/3/4, METEOR, ROUGE-L, CIDEr (7 metrics)
Training	Standard Adam	AdamW + warm-up + cosine decay + label smoothing + AMP
Analysis	Loss curves only	EDA, encoder PCA, attention layer/head decomposition

VIII. Observations

A. Novelty and Distinguishing Factors

Compared to the most closely related open-source reference (`zarzouram/image_captioning_with_transformers`), this work introduces several meaningful advances summarised in Table VII.

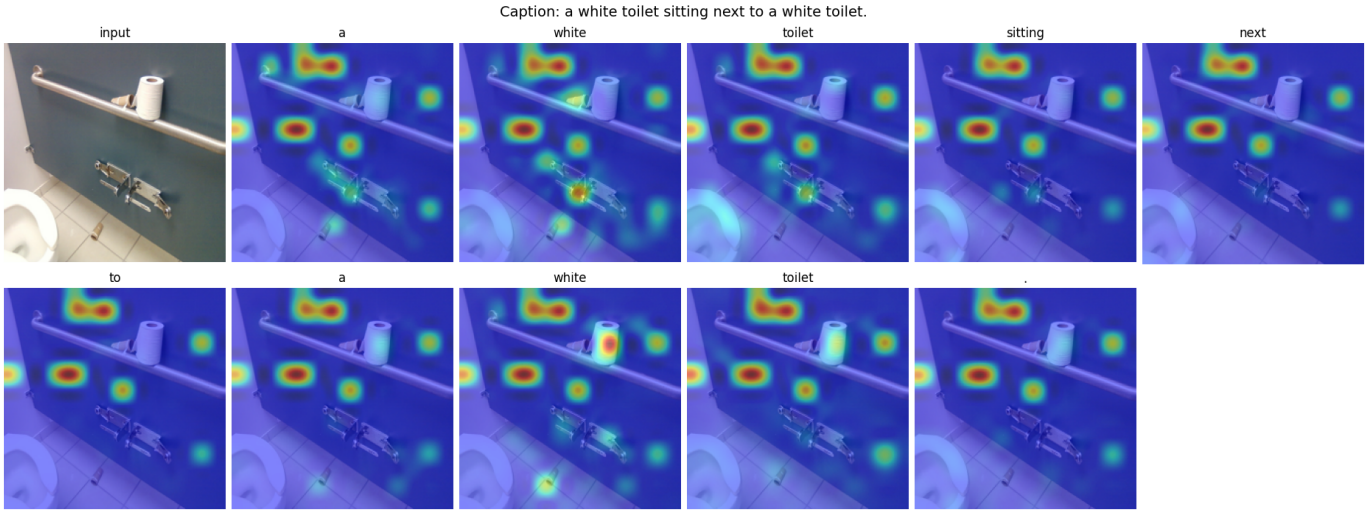
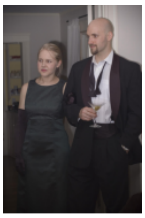


Fig. 4. Cross-attention heatmaps showing word-to-image-patch grounding for generated words from the custom Transformer decoder.



Epoch 1: a white and a large large large large large … white white white
Epoch 3: a green and white kite flying in the air.
Epoch 6: a green and white frisbee in a field.
Epoch 9: a green and white kite is in the grass.
Epoch 12: a blue and white kite is in the grass.
Human: a surf board leaning on a wheel barrel



Epoch 1: a man and a man standing in a room.
Epoch 3: a man and a woman standing in a room.
Epoch 6: a man and a woman posing for a picture.
Epoch 9: a man and a woman posing for a picture.
Epoch 12: a man and a woman posing for a picture.
Human: The couple are dressed up and posing for photos.



Epoch 1: a street sign with a sign and a street sign.
Epoch 3: a street sign with a sign on it.
Epoch 6: a sign on a pole in front of a building.
Epoch 9: a sign that is on a pole with a sign.
Epoch 12: a sign that has a sign on it.
Human: A worn and a new sign for the same Mexican food restaurant.



Epoch 1: a group of giraffes in a field.
Epoch 3: a herd of sheep grazing in a field.
Epoch 6: a herd of sheep grazing in a field.
Epoch 9: a herd of sheep standing on top of a lush green field.
Epoch 12: a herd of sheep grazing on a lush green field.
Human: A herd of sheep grazing on a green grass covered piece of land next to a forest.

Fig. 5. Caption evolution across epochs 1, 3, 6, 9, and 12 on fixed validation monitor images.

B. Model Strengths

The model demonstrates: (1) stable and reproducible convergence (fixed seed = 42) with no signs of overfitting across 12 epochs; (2) fully interpretable word-level cross-attention heatmaps; (3) robust tokenisation via BERT WordPiece eliminating out-of-vocabulary tokens; and (4) strong beam search performance yielding CIDEr > 1.0.

C. Limitations and Failure Cases

Vocabulary utilization analysis reveals an inherent compression effect: across 5,000 validation images, human annotators employed 7,178 distinct words, whereas the model utilized 480 distinct words while generating 3,440 unique captions. The model tends to rely on standard syntactic templates (e.g., *sitting on top of*, *standing in a room*) rather than rarer synonyms. Furthermore, per-image CIDEr ranking reveals that while prototypical object scenes achieve CIDEr > 2.0, heavily occluded scenes, extreme aspect ratios, or rare visual concepts yield lower scores near zero. Object hallucination is occasionally observed when visual context is ambiguous, and fine-grained attribute binding (e.g., *a red car next to a blue bicycle*) remains challenging. Finally, the frozen encoder cannot adapt its low-level visual representations, motivating partial encoder fine-tuning in future work.

IX. Conclusion and Future Work

A. Conclusion

This project successfully developed, trained, and evaluated a complete Vision-Language image captioning system combining a pretrained Vision Transformer (ViT-B/16) encoder with a custom six-layer Transformer decoder. Trained for 12 epochs on 118,287 MS COCO 2017 images, the model achieves a validation perplexity of 9.73, BLEU-4 = 0.3225, and CIDEr = 1.0385 with beam search ($k = 3$). The custom decoder layer's native attention return mechanism provides explainability without modifying library source code.

B. Future Work

Promising future extensions include:

1) **Partial Encoder Fine-Tuning:** Unfreezing the last 2 ViT blocks with lower learning rate (1×10^{-5}) to boost CIDEr beyond 1.1;
2) **Self-Critical Sequence Training (SCST):** Direct CIDEr optimisation via REINFORCE policy gradients;
3) **Larger Foundation Encoders:** Integrating CLIP ViT-L/14 for richer zero-shot semantic features;
4) **Multilingual Captioning:** Replacing WordPiece with mBERT or XLM-RoBERTa tokenisers.

Code Availability

The complete source code, trained checkpoints, executed Jupyter notebooks, evaluation suites, and LaTeX reports are publicly accessible on GitHub at:

https://github.com/Waseem-Irfan-100/Visual-Language-image-captioning-using-Transformers.git

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